Lecture plan · for the lecturer

Safe, accountable agents

AI agents · University · Lecture 4

Time
60 min

Materials
Projector or board; The lecture slides and the seminar sheet from the kit; Phones or laptops with Darsi, for the lab

Learning goals

- Classify agent actions.
- Apply least privilege and approval.
- Use governance frameworks.

Activity: Review the risks

1. Warm-up (5 min): Read the email incident and ask students to assign responsibility.
2. List (15 min): Groups list each tool of a campus assistant and its worst misuse.
3. Control (20 min): Assign a scope limit, approval, logging or denial to each tool.
4. Govern (15 min): Map the controls to NIST's govern, map, measure and manage.
5. Wrap-up (5 min): Students write the muddiest point of the lecture and one question; read them before next week.

Discussion

- Which tool was riskiest?
- Where would approval fatigue appear?
- Who owns the agent?

Exit ticket

- Name one tool you would deny an agent entirely.

Try it in your next lecture
Give groups the tool list of a campus assistant agent; each fills a table of worst misuse, reversibility and control for every tool, then compare tables and agree approval rules.

Seminar sheet · for students

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Name _____ Group _____ Date _____

1 **Which design would have prevented the email to all students?**

◯ A friendlier prompt ◯ A recipient limit plus approval for bulk sends ◯ A faster model

2 **Set the limits.**

A reminder agent should send to at most _____ recipient per task, and any bulk send should need human _____.

Word bank: review later · approval · 1 · all

3 **Which actions should usually require human approval? Choose all that apply.**

☐ Emailing the whole faculty ☐ Deleting student records ☐ Paying an invoice
☐ Reading a public timetable

4 **Requiring human approval for every action, including reads, can make an agent less safe.**

◯ True ◯ False

5 **Match each control to the risk it addresses.**

Least privilege	• • • •	Unclear accountability
Approval gate	• • • •	A runaway loop
Audit log	• • • •	An over-permissioned tool
Stop switch	• • • •	An irreversible action

Answers · for the lecturer

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1 **A recipient limit plus approval for bulk sends**

Limits and approval stop the action itself.

2 **A reminder agent should send to at most 1 recipient per task, and any bulk send should need human approval.**

Scope the tool to the task and gate wide-reaching actions.

3 **Paying an invoice; Deleting student records; Emailing the whole faculty**

Read-only access to public data changes nothing.

4 **True**

Flooded reviewers rubber-stamp; reserve approval for actions that warrant it.

5 **Least privilege — An over-permissioned tool**
Approval gate — An irreversible action
Audit log — Unclear accountability
Stop switch — A runaway loop

Layered controls cover different failures.

✎ **For you to think about**

If a student's agent caused harm in a course project, who would be accountable under your current rules?